7

Rose

The next morning, Rose winced as Léa braided her hair.

“Ow,” Rose said, lifting a hand to her head, “you’re pulling too tight.”

“I’m sorry,” Léa said, “I’ll redo it.”

“Is everything all right?” Rose studied her sister’s reflection in the mirror. Dark circles rimmed her eyes. Maybe she was tired. Léa was often short-tempered when she was tired. But something seemed different about her today. And then Rose noticed the light coming in from the window, the glow of it on the mirror like a drop of water gleaming on a blade of glass. And all she could think about was how to recreate that light on paper.

“We need to finish the harvest today,” Léa said, carefully plaiting Rose’s hair.

“Why today?”

“The authorities will come in a week to collect the wine.” Léa pursed her lips. “If we work through lunch, do you think we can finish today?”

It was the one day during the week that Paulette had no school. She would be following Rose around, asking questions, trying to get her attention. “I think we could, but I need to give Paulette a task to keep her busy and out of our way.”

Léa slid Rose’s two braids forward over her shoulder. “Then you must do that,” she said.

At breakfast, Paulette was still in her pajamas, one of the perks of not having to rush out to school. Rose smiled at her. “I hope you’re planning on getting dressed. I need your help today.”

“Oh?” Paulette’s hands clapped and her legs swung under the table.

“Léa and I must work throughout the day, with no time for lunch, to